significantly. However, by July 2021, at the time of writing, they had begun to change again. Crucially, the wider trend persisted: of a huge gap between people's negative perception of their own employment prospects and the economy as a whole in the present vis-à-vis their expectations over the next twelve months on both counts. The RBI reported that its respondents in May 2021 rated their net perception of the economic situation in percentage response terms at -75 and their own employment prospects at -74.9. By July 2021, these net perception numbers had improved only marginally to -69 and -68.2 respectively. However, when asked about future expectations about the economy over the next twelve months, compared to the present, the net perception changed significantly from -18.3 in May 2021 to -4.8 in July 2021. When people were asked about their own future employment prospects, the net sentiment changed from -13 in May 2021 to +0.9 in July 2021. RBI, *Consumer Confidence Survey*, 6 August 2021, conducted in 5,384 households in thirteen cities and available on https://m.rbi.org.in/scriptS/BimonthlyPublications.aspx?head=Consumer%20Confidence%20Survey%20-%20Bi-monthly.

28. Arvind Subramanian, *Of Counsel: The Challenges of the Modi–Jaitley Economy* (New Delhi: Penguin, 2018), pp. 94–101.

29. Details from Minister of State (Independent Charge) for Labour and Employment Santosh Gangwar's various replies to Lok Sabha on 14 September 2020 to Unstarred Questions Nos, 174, 197, 188; and on 15 September 2020 to Unstarred Question No. 294. Rations constitute 5 kg of wheat or rice and 1 kg of preferred pulses per person per month.

30. Initial data from author's interview with Dinesh Sharma, deputy chief minister, UP. A briefer version of this was published as 'We want companies leaving China to come to India instead of going to Vietnam or elsewhere', *The Times of India*, 14 June 2020. Updated later from UP government's internal note on 16 September 2020. I am grateful to Pravin Kumar for providing updated government numbers.

31. See the critique on 'administrative approach' to economy by Rathin Roy, managing director (research and policy), Overseas